
International State Building and Civilian Preferences: Experimental Evidence from Liberia

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Abstract While often described as a unified process imposed by external actors on weak, conflict-ridden countries, international state building increasingly comprises a variety of actors involved in different ways in (re)building a diverse set of institutions. Civilian preferences are often excluded from this fragmented environment. We identify and explicate three dimensions along which postconflict state building meaningfully varies: the actor involved, the type of institution targeted, and the form of involvement. We then examine how variation along each dimension impacts civilians' state-building preferences with two rounds of original survey experiments fielded in Liberia. We find that Liberians largely prefer state-building processes overseen by a subset of international actors; that they prefer state building focused on security-oriented institutions over non-security-oriented institutions; and that different forms of involvement in the process meaningfully influence their preferences. We also find that these preferences depend on civilians' characteristics. Ultimately, we provide an initial, conceptual mapping of the diversified landscape of international state building, as well as an empirical "unpacking" of the conditions that may shape civilians' preferences toward the process.

Fragile and war-torn countries often exacerbate domestic instability and increase the likelihood of transnational threats, including armed conflicts, illicit activities, and humanitarian crises.¹ The potential spillover effects of these conditions have been a concern for policymakers around the world, leading to robust international state-building projects aimed at promoting the performance, capacity, and responsiveness of state institutions.²

Much of the literature on international state building treats it as a monolithic process whereby the international community imposes reform efforts to strengthen domestic institutions.³ However, despite becoming a core component of the "liberal

1. Lee 2022; Paris and Sisk 2009; Patrick 2011.

2. Berg 2022; Campbell and Matanock 2024; Fukuyama 2014; Krasner 2004; Krasner and Risse 2014; Lake 2016.

3. Girod 2015; Lake 2016; Lee 2022; Paris and Sisk 2009; Richmond 2014.

international order,”⁴ the landscape of international state building is increasingly fragmented. A wide variety of actors, including the United Nations (UN), the European Union (EU), the United States (US), and China, engage in state-building processes. Each may seek different objectives and use different implementation strategies. Moreover, while civilians are central to successful state-building efforts, they may interpret this fragmentation in a variety of ways, which may, in turn, affect whether they accept the (re)construction of state institutions by international actors.⁵ Consequently, we ask: how does international state building vary, what preferences do civilians have toward the process, and are civilians unified in their preferences?

We answer these questions in two steps. First, we identify and explicate variation in international state building along three dimensions: the actor involved; the type of institution targeted; and the form of involvement. Second, we leverage an original conjoint experiment fielded in multiple rounds across three locations in postconflict Liberia to examine how civilians’ state-building preferences vary along each of these three dimensions. We find that civilians strongly prefer state-building processes overseen by the UN or the US over those administered by China; they also prefer state-building efforts performed by the Liberian government over those implemented by China. We also find that civilians prefer the (re)construction of security-oriented institutions over non-security-oriented institutions and that they prefer less direct forms of state-building engagement. Importantly, however, these results are not uniform across respondents: preferences vary by sex, socioeconomic status, and experiences of wartime violence. We explore this heterogeneity in greater detail by leveraging additional questions in our surveys.

Conducting an initial foray into understanding civilian preferences around international state building, we make several contributions. First, we provide researchers with a conceptual mapping of three primary dimensions of international state building. While any state-building process undoubtedly includes additional nuance, we maintain that these three features meaningfully capture variation in *who* engages in (re)building *which* type of state institution, and *how* they do so.

Second, we shift the focus of the state-building literature away from domestic elites and international actors⁶ and toward civilians. Civilians often have little say in state-building processes, yet their preferences are important for long-term peace, security, and stability.⁷ While scholars have examined the conditions under which government institutions become legitimate,⁸ less attention has been paid to civilians’ perceptions of the international state-building process. As in work that has looked at aid-donor characteristics,⁹ we examine the public’s assessment of the various features that

4. Fukuyama 2014; Paris and Sisk 2009; Patrick 2011.

5. Blair and Roessler 2021; Karim 2020b; Risse 2011.

6. Berg 2022.

7. Blair and Roessler 2021; Nomikos 2022.

8. Blair and Roessler 2021; Karim 2020b; Risse 2011.

9. Kim et al. 2025.

compose international state-building efforts. But we also join recent efforts to assess how variation in actor attribution impacts public perceptions of state institutions.¹⁰

Third, we contribute to the literature on peacekeeping and international interventions by showing that there is local, micro-level support for third-party enforcement of various processes in conflict-affected countries.¹¹ Importantly, while our findings may qualify previous work suggesting that domestic actors often resist or undermine international interventions,¹² they emphasize that such support is not inevitable but depends on the actor, their form of involvement, and the type of targeted institution.

Finally, we also weigh in on discussions of the international engagement of illiberal and emerging powers.¹³ Our findings suggest that, despite China's increased investment in state-building projects around the world,¹⁴ many civilians may ultimately prefer other actors, including their own government.

The Importance of Civilian Preferences in a Fragmented International State-Building Process

We define international state building as any “externally led social engineering reflected in efforts by the international community and individual states to rebuild states.”¹⁵ While it may include a variety of processes, international state building includes actions aimed at creating, reforming, or strengthening state institutions,¹⁶ with the primary goal of establishing a state that is “regarded as legitimate by the people over whom it exercises authority.”¹⁷ Consequently, it usually takes place in weak and failing states—particularly those that have experienced severe violence or conflict.¹⁸

Much of the literature understands international state building as emanating from one of two processes.¹⁹ It may be provided to overcome the resources or enforcement restrictions that conflict-affected countries face,²⁰ or it may be imposed on societies as a model for building “legitimate” states under the “liberal international order.”²¹ In both cases, it is treated as a unified, monolithic process.²² However, the state-building landscape has become increasingly fragmented, with a wide array of actors involved in various ways in rebuilding a variety of state institutions. For example, alongside the UN and the US—the historically

10. Mailhot 2025c; Matanock 2020.

11. Doyle and Sambanis 2000, 2006; Fortna 2008; Mailhot 2025a; Mironova and Whitt 2017; Nomikos 2022; Walter 2002; Walter, Howard, and Fortna 2021.

12. Barma 2016; Mac Ginty 2011; Richmond 2014; Russell and Sambanis 2022.

13. Richmond and Tellidis 2014; Weiss 2019; Weiss and Wallace 2021.

14. Brautigam 2011; Dreher et al. 2022.

15. Lake 2016, 1.

16. Call and Cousens 2008.

17. Lake 2016, 1.

18. Hutchison and Johnson 2011; Lee and Zhang 2017; Paris and Sisk 2009; Patrick 2011.

19. Lee 2022.

20. Berg 2022; Girod 2015; Matanock 2020.

21. Barma 2016; Call and Cousens 2008; Campbell 2018; Chesterman 2004; Dodge 2013; Lake 2016; Paris and Sisk 2009; Richmond 2014.

22. Lee 2022.

preeminent bilateral state builder—are other bilateral actors and regional state builders. They include Western actors, such as the EU, the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe (OSCE), and Sweden, as well as non-Western, illiberal actors, such as China and Russia.²³

Moreover, international state builders often use a variety of distinct, and at times divergent, state-building efforts.²⁴ For example, over the past twenty-five years, a variety of actors have sought to reform and strengthen different state institutions in Tajikistan through various initiatives. China and the US have provided financial resources and equipment to the country's security (military and police) institutions to combat border insecurity, drug trafficking, and terrorism, while the OSCE has worked closely with Dushanbe to monitor and train officials in Tajikistan's human rights and anticorruption institutions.²⁵

Though international state builders primarily engage with domestic elites,²⁶ understanding civilians' perceptions of the increasingly fragmented international state-building process is important for several reasons. First, civilian preferences regarding this process may affect their overall perception of its outcomes—that is, whether they find state institutions rebuilt by international actors legitimate. While some research finds that international state building has largely failed or had minimal effect,²⁷ this literature often relies on measurements of “success” that are distinct from those tied to civilian perceptions. However, civilians do not always reject international state-building processes,²⁸ and there is no clear definition of what constitutes “success” for civilians, as they may understand it in a variety of ways.²⁹ Thus, we maintain that examining civilian preferences for how international state building occurs is important because civilians who support various components of these processes may find their outcomes more legitimate.

Relatedly, because a core goal of contemporary state building is the (re)establishment of the social contract between the state and its citizens,³⁰ failing to consider the latter's preferences about the “terms” of the contract may undermine such efforts. In fact, the literature on constitution building emphasizes the importance of civilians' attitudes in promoting public buy-in.³¹ In this way, perceptions of the process of international state building may affect the degree to which the social contract is (re)established in the postconflict period.

Third, perceptions of the international state-building process may impact individuals' political behavior and countries' broader political trajectory. Citizens of postconflict Kosovo, for example, have taken to the streets in protest of the UN's direct management

23. Brautigam 2011; Dreher et al. 2022; Fisher and Anderson 2015; Kriner, Mailhot, and Karim 2022; Strange 2024; Zeitz 2021.

24. Bearce and Tirone 2010.

25. Mailhot 2025b; Mailhot, Kriner, and Karim 2022.

26. Berg 2022.

27. Autesserre 2014; Barma 2016; Berg 2022; Campbell 2018; Lake 2016.

28. Blair, Marty, and Philip 2022; Mailhot 2025c; Matanock 2020; Nomikos 2022.

29. Firschow 2018.

30. Blair 2019; Doyle and Sambanis 2006; Lake 2010; Paris and Sisk 2009.

31. Eisenstadt, LeVan, and Maboudi 2017; Ginsburg, Elkins, and Blount 2009; Moehler 2008.

of their country's state-building process,³² as well as the EU mission's executive authority over various institutional reforms.³³ In extreme cases, such perceptions may even alter leaders' election prospects. For example, the decision of Manasseh Sogavare, the former prime minister of the Solomon Islands, to withdraw from re-election in 2024 was partly due to domestic criticism of his close relations with Beijing and China's focus on rebuilding public infrastructure over healthcare institutions.³⁴

Finally, paying attention to civilian preferences toward international state building helps promote "local ownership" of the process.³⁵ One of the main criticisms of international state building is that it ignores local needs and preferences.³⁶ Only by understanding these preferences can changes be made to the process that better align it with what local populations may want.

Components of the International State-Building Process

We have seen that civilians often hold preferences toward internationally backed state-building processes that are consequentially meaningful. However, we have not yet considered what features of these processes might lead to differing attitudes. Here, we explicate three primary dimensions along which international state building—and, consequently, people's preferences regarding it—may vary: the actor involved; the target institution; and the form of involvement.

First, international state builders can vary according to type—that is, their status as either a multilateral or bilateral actor. Multilateral actors include international organizations, such as the EU, OSCE, or UN—each of which engages in state-building activities primarily through the missions they deploy to recipient countries.³⁷ Additionally, individual states may engage in state-building activities through bilateral programs. Moving beyond mere foreign aid, states engage in bilateral state building when their intervention involves a form of "shared sovereignty."³⁸ This might include, for example, arrangements to increase the capacity of a postconflict country's police or military force.³⁹ While the US is one of the largest bilateral state-building actors, many other countries have also been involved in such activities. For example, Australia has played a central role in postconflict police reform throughout Oceania,⁴⁰ while the UK has engaged in state-building interventions in Sierra Leone.⁴¹

There is also meaningful variation within bilateral efforts. In particular, while Western states have historically been the preeminent bilateral state builders,

32. Perritt 2009.

33. Mahr 2021.

34. Needham 2024; Needham and Craymer 2024.

35. Autesserre 2014, 2017; von Billerbeck 2017; Ejodus 2017.

36. Autesserre 2017, 2014; Firchow 2018.

37. Mailhot 2025b.

38. Cooley and Spruyt 2009; Krasner 2004.

39. Joyce 2020; Mailhot, Kriner, and Karim 2022.

40. Dinnen, McLeod, and Peake 2008.

41. Albrecht and Jackson 2014.

non-Western countries, including China and Russia, have increasingly taken on a leading role. For example, over the past two decades, China has increased its state-building support in Africa, Asia, and Latin America through various infrastructure and security assistance programs.⁴² Importantly, while Western states may seek to institutionalize liberal, democratic norms in their state-building programs abroad,⁴³ non-Western states like China neither actively export nor actively condemn antidemocratic actions in recipient states.⁴⁴ Their state-building practices may be more narrowly directed at furthering strategic national interests.⁴⁵ Nevertheless, such an orientation represents a clear distinction among bilateral state builders.

Second, actors may target different *types of institutions* in the state-building process. On the one hand, traditional state-building models suggest that expanding the administrative state is crucial, as a necessary first step in both building state capacity and increasing state legitimacy.⁴⁶ Indeed, in many historic state-building processes, administrative state institutions took precedence before other state institutions emerged, including security.⁴⁷

On the other hand, contemporary state-building projects often take place in weak, failed, or conflict-affected states. Consequently, while it may include the provision of various goods and services, a sequencing of state-building activities necessarily unfolds, with certain institutions taking a priority over others. As Krasner and Risse and Lake demonstrate, security provision often becomes a first-order concern within today's postconflict state-building processes, as states with increased security capacities are largely understood to be less prone to armed conflict and criminal violence.⁴⁸ Thus, while any state-building effort may incorporate aspects of both, a meaningful distinction can be made here between security-oriented and non-security-oriented institutions. The former are mainly institutions like the military and police; the latter comprise a wider variety of administrative institutions, such as postal services, social services, and regulatory bodies.

Third, international state building may vary with respect to actors' *form of involvement*.⁴⁹ At one end of the spectrum, an actor may be directly or heavily involved with a given state-building reform. This often arises when the actor has a degree of independent or executive oversight in the process. UN transitional administrations in Cambodia, East Timor, and Kosovo, for example, held managerial, decision-making authority in each country's initial, postconflict, state-building period. Thus, they were responsible for designing and implementing a variety of institutional reforms in each country with comparatively less input from domestic actors.⁵⁰

42. Arewa 2016; Brautigam 2011; Dreher et al. 2022; Kriner, Mailhot, and Karim 2022; Wolf, Wang, and Warner 2013.

43. Joyce 2020.

44. Weiss 2019; Weiss and Wallace 2021.

45. Brautigam 2011; Dreher et al. 2018, 2022; Fung 2019.

46. Albertus 2017, 2021; Hendrix 2010.

47. Carpenter 2000; Obert 2018; Schwartz 2021; Van de Walle and Scott 2011.

48. Krasner and Risse 2014; Lake 2016. See also Berg 2022; Toft 2009.

49. Mailhot 2025b.

50. Chesterman 2004.

At the other end of the spectrum, an actor may be indirectly involved in a state-building initiative, taking a more “hands-off” approach.⁵¹ In these instances, for example, state builders may “monitor” or provide financial or technical assistance. For example, China has regularly provided Tajikistan’s security institutions with testing equipment and simulation training.⁵² In such contexts, while state-building efforts are undoubtedly taking place, the international actors have less of a direct influence over the specific contours of the process.

Measuring Civilian Preferences for International State Building

Case Selection: State Building in Liberia

We leverage insights from postconflict Liberia to examine how variation along each of these three dimensions influences civilians’ preferences for postconflict state building. Liberia represents a “crucial” case for our analyses because it has undergone an extensive state-building process, with a variety of international actors involved in rebuilding a variety of institutions. Although Liberia has received assistance from many different international actors (including Canada, the EU, and Sweden), the UN, US, and China represent the main international statebuilders.

The UN has been deeply involved in Liberia’s state-building process since the end of the country’s second civil war, in 2003. With the adoption of the Accra Peace Agreement, the UN Security Council authorized the establishment of a multidimensional peacekeeping force, the UN Mission in Liberia (UNMIL).⁵³ The mission was involved in a variety of state-building tasks, including reformation of the judiciary and democratic institutions, but it was primarily involved in reforming the country’s security sector. For example, during its fourteen-year deployment period (2003–2018), UNMIL contributed nearly USD 5 billion and thousands of personnel toward reforming the country’s police force.⁵⁴

In contrast, the US has a long history of state building in Liberia. In 1822, the American Colonization Society established the Colony of Liberia as a colony of freed slaves on the African coast.⁵⁵ Fondly referring to Liberia as the US’s fifty-first state, many Liberians consider the US one of their country’s strongest allies.⁵⁶ Indeed, this “special relationship” has solidified over time through the consistent engagement of the US in security activities in the country and its commitment to (re)building Liberia’s security sector. For example, the US helped establish Liberia’s armed forces throughout the twentieth century. Since its civil wars, Liberia has been one of the

51. The decision to take on “limited” roles may have myriad reasons, including funding and personnel commitments or a negotiated arrangement with the host country. Campbell and Matanock 2024; Matanock 2014.

52. Dreher, Fuchs, Parks, et al. 2021; Ibragimova 2021.

53. UN Security Council Resolution 1509 (2003).

54. Mailhot, Kriner, and Karim 2022.

55. Ciment 2013.

56. Ibid.; Hahn 2020.

main recipients on the African continent of security-oriented state-building assistance from the US.⁵⁷

China is the newest of these three state-building actors. Initially gaining a foothold in the country via personnel contributions to UNMIL, China now invests consistently in Liberia. Its state-building efforts focus on public infrastructure. For example, it has invested heavily in the (re)construction of roads, bridges, and ministerial and sports complexes in both the capital and rural areas. Moreover, China has also contributed to Liberia's education system, by (re)constructing school and university buildings,⁵⁸ and to its security sector.⁵⁹

Though undoubtedly a crucial case, Liberia also represents a "difficult" test for our analyses. Studies have suggested that Liberia represents a generally successful case of postconflict state building, and such processes are often treated as homogeneous and unified.⁶⁰ Thus it may be more difficult to identify any meaningful variation in civilian preferences along each of the three dimensions. Consequently, if we find any significant differences in Liberians' attitudes along each dimension of the state-building process, then we may expect variation to be observed in other postconflict countries, where internationally backed state building is often *more* divisive.

Research Design

We measure civilians' preferences for each dimension of international state building using a set of conjoint experiments embedded in two rounds of representative surveys implemented in three locations across Liberia: Monrovia, Bong Mines, and Gbarnga (Table 1). We selected these locations because of their variation across several factors that may condition civilians' experience of and position on postconflict state building: community type, exposure to wartime violence, and relative exposure to postconflict state-building processes.

The first round of the survey was conducted in January 2020. The second round, conducted in January 2022, replicates the conjoint experiment (with a slight modification, as described later) and was implemented to assess whether findings from the first round are robust across location and time (for example, before and after the COVID-19 pandemic declaration). Table 2 describes the two rounds.

Survey Recruitment and Implementation

We sampled between 500 and 1,700 adult respondents in each location.⁶¹ To obtain representative samples, we used a two-stage sampling procedure. Within each city/community, enumerator areas (EAs) were established according to common

57. Joyce 2020, 2022; Kriner, Mailhot, and Karim 2022.

58. Moumouni 2018.

59. Carrozza and Marsh 2022.

60. Karim 2020a; Martin-Brûlé 2016.

61. Sample size is based on the total population in each location. For power analyses of each survey round, see section 3 of the appendix; for balance tests, see section 4 of the appendix.

TABLE 1. *Relative empirical variation in the wartime and postconflict state-building experiences of three locations in Liberia*

	Community type	State-sponsored wartime violence	Exposure to inter-national state building	Number of different state builders	Variation in state builders' involvement
<i>Bong Mines</i>	Rural (village)	Low	Low	Low	Low
<i>Gbarnga</i>	Rural (town)	Mid	Mid	Mid	Mid
<i>Monrovia</i>	Urban	High	High	High	High

Note: Wartime violence is measured by battle-related deaths, from Gleditsch et al. 2002.

TABLE 2. *Survey locations, dates, and respondent totals*

Location	Implementation date	Respondents
Monrovia (round 1)	January/February 2020	1,332
Bong Mines (round 2)	January 2022	503
Gbarnga (round 2)	January 2022	704
Monrovia (round 2)	January 2022	1,709

geographic boundaries. We adopted a stratified sampling procedure to select the number of respondents in each EA proportional to the total population in each location, according to Liberia's most recent census. From there, enumerators engaged in a random-walk procedure to select a dwelling for respondent selection: after starting in each EA's community market or central plaza, the enumerator randomly selected a street to walk down, alternating on each street between selecting the third house on the right and the third house on the left. Once a dwelling was identified, the enumerator selected a random adult to interview using a Kish table. Following each interview, the enumerator continued to the end of the street and repeated the random selection process.

The surveys were administered face to face in the first language of the respondent and by enumerators of the same sex as the respondent. Each survey interview took about fifty minutes to complete, beginning with introduction and consent and ending with a debriefing. Each survey included additional questions on baseline characteristics, including income level, sex, and exposure to wartime violence.

Research Ethics

Approval from an institutional review board (or the local equivalent) is the minimum requirement to meet our institutions' standards for research with human

participants.⁶² However, the sensitivity of the survey and the nature of the face-to-face interviews warrant additional ethical considerations.

First, we understand that postconflict state-building processes may be highly contentious; having enumerators ask individuals throughout a community about the topic might raise suspicion and fears, making them—and willing participants—a potential target. On top of the social dimension are the physical risks inherent in survey enumeration. While the risks that enumerators and respondents face cannot be completely eradicated, it is our duty to eliminate the ones we can and minimize the others. We sought to do so in three ways. First, where possible, enumerators were instructed to notify and receive approval from local leaders before conducting interviews. Second, each enumerator was paired with a member of the opposite sex in a single EA; this not only allowed the team to ensure that the enumerator and their respondent were of the same sex but also guaranteed that no enumerator was traveling alone. Third, we provided insurance for our research team so that we could provide medical care in the case of injury during the survey.

We also understand that unforeseen circumstances can put individual enumerators, or more generally the team and project, in danger. Consequently, we worked with the local survey team to construct a general safety plan outlining various conditions under which the project would be paused or terminated. In addition, as a team, we checked in with each other daily to ensure that each enumerator was safe and secure. Finally, seeking to minimize the gap between the ethical standards to which academic institutions adhere in the Global North and those in place in other regions of the world, we also obtained approval from the University of Liberia's Institutional Review Board.

Structure and Modeling of the Conjoint Experiment

As noted, we use a choice-based conjoint experiment embedded in each of the surveys.⁶³ Although additional care must be taken when interpreting their results,⁶⁴ conjoint experiments are useful over other survey experiments because they allow us not only to directly control for exposure to each independent variable of interest but also to test several causal relationships present across the hypotheses simultaneously.⁶⁵ Moreover, these factors more accurately represent real-world decision-making processes than other survey experiments,⁶⁶ while also allowing individuals to

62. The surveys were reviewed and approved by three institutional review boards: Cornell University's IRB (IRB1911009186), Oxford University's Central University Research Ethics Committee (R57153), and the University of Liberia's IRB (19-12-192).

63. The conjoint experiment is forced-choice. While this may not represent the natural attitudes of all citizens, we use this structure for two reasons. First, because this is an initial foray into studying civilians' preferences for international state building, we prioritized identifying individuals' core preferences. Second, and relatedly, this structure also matches much of the empirical reality of postconflict state-building processes, given the prioritization and sequentialization that necessarily and often arise in postconflict state-building processes. Paris 2004; Wolff 2011.

64. Abramson, Kocak, and Magazinnik 2022.

65. Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto 2014.

66. Hauser 2007. Fully randomized conjoint survey experiments, such as these, may also be useful in reducing social desirability bias (Horiuchi, Markovich, and Yamamoto 2021). This is important, given that

respond to sensitive aspects of each topic more discretely, thus more accurately capturing their true preferences.⁶⁷

The attributes in the conjoint experiment correspond to the primary dimensions of international state building, and each feature therein represents the operationalization of the corresponding dimension. The first dimension is the actor involved—here the UN, the US, or China. We choose this set for two reasons. First, we include a *variety* of actors both to examine how such variation may shape state-building preferences and to minimize any biases we may find if we rely on a single actor. Second, we include *these* three actors because of their prevalence in Liberia. For a baseline, we use the recipient state: the Liberian government.

The second dimension is the type of institution. As noted, our primary distinction is between security-oriented and non-security-oriented institutions. For the former, we specify a “special forces” team: the Armed Forces of Liberia Special Forces Team. This operationalization represents an institution aimed at promoting the physical security of civilians as it demonstrates a clear strengthening of the country’s armed forces. For the latter, we use either the Liberian Postal Service (round 1) or the Liberian Land Authority (round 2). These are examples of two common state-building institutions: postal services and land-granting authorities.⁶⁸ Consulting with the local research team and country experts, we opted for the post office in the first round because of its role in the bureaucratic expansion of states.⁶⁹ In the second round, we chose the land authority because of its role in representing the legal expansion of the state. Given the importance of land issues in Liberia,⁷⁰ the land authority represents a potentially more “desirable” non-security-oriented institution and thus a harder test for any distinctions between security and nonsecurity institutions. Nevertheless, each institution represents fundamental services that a contemporary state is meant to provide and therefore is central to postconflict state-building processes.⁷¹

Crucially, we ensured that it was plausible that each international actor engaged with each institution through each form of involvement. For example, while China has been primarily involved in expanding non-security-oriented institutions in Liberia, it has also helped reform the country’s security sector through cooperative

social desirability bias may be particularly acute in surveys conducted in a postconflict setting, where respondents may feel pressured to select actors which have contributed significantly to the state-building efforts or institutions which dominate the political and social environment.

67. For example, other studies use conjoint experiments to examine public opinion on an array of sensitive topics, including immigration (Bansak, Hainmueller, and Hangartner 2016; Hainmueller and Hopkins 2015) and political candidates (Franchino and Zucchini 2015).

68. Albertus 2017, 2021; Schwartz 2021; Van de Walle and Scott 2011.

69. Carpenter 2000; Schwartz 2021.

70. Christensen, Hartman, and Samii 2021; Kepe and Suah 2021.

71. Ministry for Foreign Affairs of Sweden 2016. We use these institutions for two additional reasons. First, we avoided other types of institutions that aim to provide “short-term” benefits because of their particularly polarizing nature. For example, there have been mixed reactions to international provision of healthcare services during the Ebola epidemic (Davies and Rushton 2017). Second, the institutions we chose have not been rebuilt in their entirety during the time of the survey, which means that civilians were not previously exposed to them, preventing the conflation of any pre-existing institutional experiences with state-building preferences.

training and technology provision.⁷² At the same time, while the UN and US have been heavily involved in security-sector reform, they have also been involved historically in building the capacity of non-security-oriented state administrations.⁷³

TABLE 3. *Outline of the conjoint experiment*

Attribute	Level	Operationalization
Actor	Domestic	Liberian government
Actor	International	United Nations
Actor	International	United States
Actor	International	China
Form of involvement	Direct state building	“has rebuilt”
Form of involvement	Indirect state building	“has monitored the reconstruction of”
Target institution	Security institution	Armed Forces of Liberia Special Forces Team
Target institution	Nonsecurity institution	Liberian Postal Service/Liberian Land Authority

The third dimension is the form of involvement in the state-building process. To capture more direct forms of state-building involvement, we use the phrase “has rebuilt.” To capture indirect, limited participation, we use the phrase “has monitored the reconstruction of.” While this dimension of international state building undoubtedly operates on a spectrum, we rely on these operationalizations for three reasons: to maximize the clarity of distinction; to match measurement decisions in recent studies;⁷⁴ and to contextualize the experiment following our consultation with the local research team. The overall design of the conjoint experiment is presented in Table 3.

The experimental portion of the survey began with the enumerator reading a short introductory statement on the task to be completed:

I would now like to provide you with a few statements of recent developments in Liberia. For each set of two statements, please identify which you find more favorable.

Enumerators then read two randomly assigned combinations of the conjoint experiment to each respondent and asked which he or she preferred. This selection process (“task”) was completed three or four times by each respondent, with a new

72. Carrozza and Marsh 2022. See also, for example, Ministry of Foreign Affairs of China 2024.

73. *Heritage News Liberia* 2023.

74. Mailhot 2025a, 2025b.

combination provided each time.⁷⁵ For example, one possible combination of statements was:⁷⁶

[1] The Liberian Government has rebuilt the Armed Forces of Liberia Special Forces Team.

[2] The United States has monitored the reconstruction of the Liberian Postal Service.

Following Leeper, Hobolt, and Tilley, we present the results derived from the marginal mean estimands for each of the attribute levels.⁷⁷ Because the conjoint experiment was forced-choice with two profiles (state-building events) in each task, values above 0.5 indicate an attribute level that *increases* the favorability of a profile over another, and values below 0.5 represent an attribute level that *decreases* it.

We expect each attribute to have an additive effect on each respondent's preference. Thus, in a standard regression framework, the probability that respondent i selected a certain state-building event S can be written as

$$\Pr(S)_i = \text{ACTOR}_i + \text{INSTITUTION}_i + \text{INVOLVEMENT}_i + \varepsilon_i$$

Because participants were asked to complete the conjoint experiment multiple times, we include robust standard errors clustered by respondent.

Results and Discussion

Figure 1 presents the primary results of the conjoint experiment, while Figure 2 presents the heterogeneous effects across three key demographic characteristics: sex, socioeconomic status, and experience of wartime violence. In this section, we highlight and expand on several key findings from the analyses.⁷⁸

Results for Actor

Regarding the state-building *actor*, we find that civilians prefer the US, the UN, and the Liberian government over China.⁷⁹ The estimates for the former, ranging from

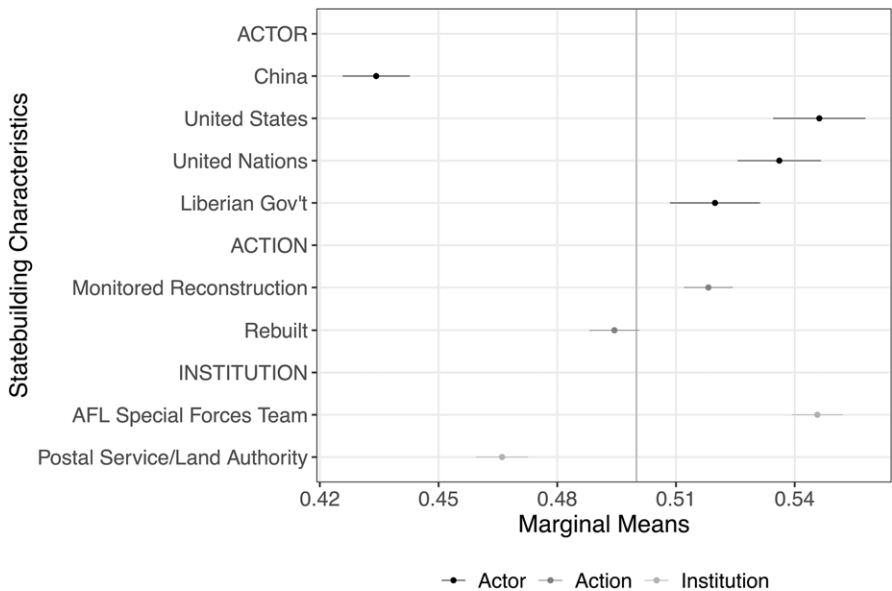
75. The number of rounds depended on the number of respondents, attributes, and levels (Orme 2010). Respondents in the first round completed it four times; those in the second round, three times. Duplicate conjoint pairs were avoided across different tasks for the same respondent.

76. We use this experimental design and selection process for two reasons. First, discerning any significant variation among small differences in survey items is a hard test for our hypotheses. Second, this design allows us to capture our outcome of interest (civilian preferences) with a minimum level of manipulation.

77. Leeper, Hobolt, and Tilley 2020. We present average marginal component effect estimates, which are substantively equivalent, in section 2 of the appendix.

78. The results by survey round are provided in section 2 of the appendix. We derived prespecified hypotheses in the pre-analysis plan (section 7 of the appendix). We present and discuss the results as they relate to these hypotheses in section 8 of the appendix.

79. These results are contrary to the hypotheses specified in our pre-analysis plan.



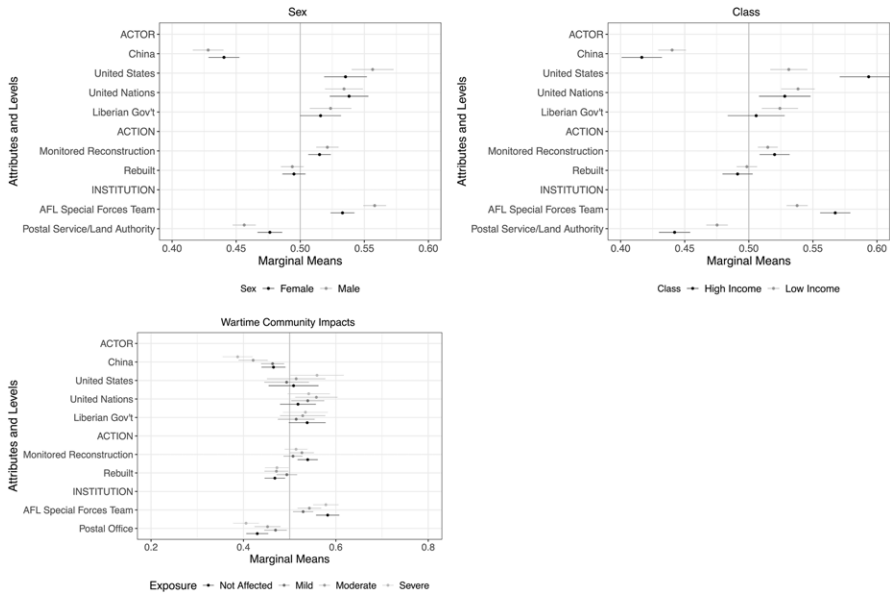
Note: Horizontal bars represent 95% confidence intervals; standard errors are clustered by respondent.

FIGURE 1. *Marginal means of attribute levels*

0.52 (Liberian government) to 0.546 (US), are positively and significantly associated with support for a given state-building process. This is particularly true for the US, with an estimand that is statistically distinct from that of the Liberian government. In contrast, China’s involvement is negatively and significantly associated with a given state-building process (an estimate of 0.434).

These results both align with and diverge from earlier scholarship. They substantiate recent scholarship by highlighting that civilians rarely hold neutral opinions on international actors⁸⁰ and reinforce other studies that find that donors’ characteristics shape public support.⁸¹ Our results are also consistent with studies that find no meaningful increase in support for China resulting from its assistance but a meaningful increase in support for the US under such conditions.⁸² The distinct impact of the US may be driven by its long-standing and close history with Liberia.⁸³ This would imply that individuals who have closer ties to the US, such as those of a higher socioeconomic status,⁸⁴ should favor the US as a state builder. Indeed, wealthier individuals are more likely to support US-backed state-building processes (Figure 2).

80. Bush and Prather 2018; Dellmuth et al. 2022; Mailhot 2025c; Nomikos 2022.
81. Kim et al. 2025.
82. Blair, Marty, and Philip 2022.
83. Ciment 2013.
84. For example, they may hold dual citizenship or have family members in the US.



Note: Horizontal bars represent 95% confidence intervals; standard errors are clustered by respondent.

FIGURE 2. *Marginal means of attribute levels by subgroup*

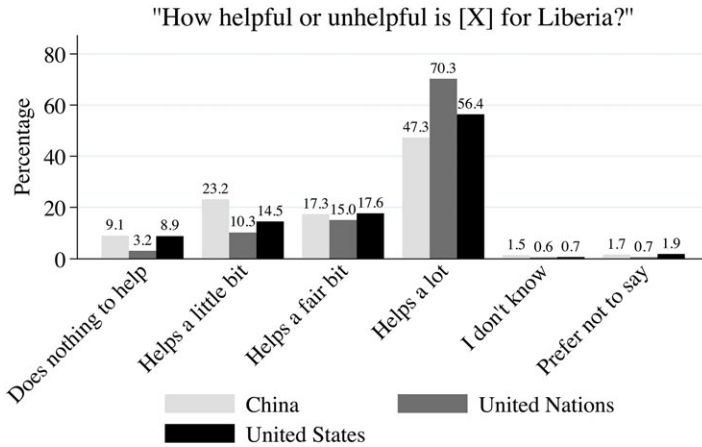
At the same time, we find the results somewhat surprising. Research has demonstrated a strong favorability toward all international donors over domestic governments when it comes to aid assistance.⁸⁵ These findings also implicitly contrast with past work showing the various benefits that come with Chinese state-building and development assistance.⁸⁶ Relatedly, the high visibility of Chinese state-building projects in the country should imply more favorability, as scholarship finds that exposure to projects—especially completed projects—consistently improves donor perceptions.⁸⁷ Indeed, Blair and Roessler find that Liberians' exposure to Chinese aid and investment improves their perceptions of Chinese donors and investors.⁸⁸ However, our findings demonstrate that respondents held relatively clear opinions of each international state builder included in the experiment (see Figure A2 in the appendix). This suggests that our results are not driven purely by respondents' disproportionately low exposure to China's previous activities in the country.

85. Milner, Nielson, and Findley 2016.

86. Brautigam 2011; Dreher et al. 2022.

87. Morgan 2019; Wellner et al. 2025.

88. Blair and Roessler 2016.



Note: The bar plot shows the distribution of respondents' answers to the question, "How helpful or unhelpful is [X] for Liberia?"

FIGURE 3. *Liberians' views on international state builders*

We find that variations in sex and socioeconomic class do not meaningfully predict opposition to China's involvement in the state-building process (Figure 2).⁸⁹ Consequently, we explore three other potential explanations for these findings. First, it may be the case that people simply hold less positive views on China's efforts in Liberia. Figure 3 suggests that this may be the case. In particular, additional survey results (round 2) demonstrate that respondents find China to be less helpful for Liberia than the UN and the US. We also find that respondents are disproportionately more likely to trust the UN and the US, as compared to the Liberian government (see Figure A4 in the appendix).

Second, the negative impact of China on respondents' state-building preferences may be driven by normative considerations. Previous work has demonstrated that civilians are more likely to support donors who are more democratic and transparent⁹⁰ because transparency and accountability promote trust.⁹¹ This means that Liberians with more authoritarian views may be more willing to support Chinese state building. Testing this proposition directly would introduce post-treatment bias, but we see some evidence for it by relying on other questions in the survey. Those who score higher on the standard authoritarian scale are more likely to trust China (see Table A17 in the appendix), suggesting that they might also prefer its state-building activities over other actors.

89. Section 2 of the appendix presents additional results by respondents' level of education and location. Similarly, we do not find any significant difference for Chinese-backed state-building processes.

90. Kim et al. 2025.

91. de Fine Licht 2014; Warren 2018.

Finally, recent studies have also found that Chinese assistance, in particular, may stoke division—increasing (real or perceived) levels of corruption, political patronage, or intergroup conflict among recipient populations,⁹² as well as the protest rate of local populations.⁹³ Victims of wartime violence may be particularly sensitive to these concerns and therefore opposed to developments that may further create political and social cleavages. Indeed, we find that those who experienced particularly severe forms of wartime violence are even less likely to prefer Chinese-backed state-building processes (Figure 2). This trend is supported by regression analyses that find those with knowledge of armed groups are less likely to trust China (Table A17 in the appendix).

Results for Type of Institution

Turning to the *type of institution*, we find that Liberians have a clear preference for state-building activities that involve the security-oriented institution (Armed Forces of Liberia Special Forces Team) over the non-security-oriented institutions (postal service/land authority). With a value of the former at 0.546 (standard error of 0.003), the estimand is eight percentage points—and *twenty-four standard deviations*—greater than that for the latter (0.466). Moreover, the estimands operate in different directions: the impact of the Armed Forces of Liberia Special Forces Team is positive and statistically significant, while the impact of the postal service/land authority is negative and statistically significant.

These preferences align with research suggesting that the reconstruction of security-oriented institutions should be prioritized to promote lasting peace.⁹⁴ This distinction appears within public opinion in other contexts, as recent work has also found that civilians place a premium on security in the postconflict period.⁹⁵ Indeed, the government of Liberia has prioritized funding the security sector, with funding increasing each year since 2019.⁹⁶

However, the literature and our findings raise important questions regarding the conditions under which civilians in postconflict countries may prioritize non-security-oriented institutions. Here, the heterogeneous effects suggest that certain populations are less likely to prefer security institutions. First, women are less likely to prefer the Armed Forces of Liberia Special Forces Team to the nonsecurity institutions. This is somewhat unsurprising, given that women across the world are less likely than men to prefer securitized policies.⁹⁷ Women may also be less willing

92. Cha 2024; Dreher, Fuchs, Hodler, et al. 2021; Dreher et al. 2022; Isaksson 2020; Isaksson and Kotsadam 2018.

93. Iacoella et al. 2021.

94. Joshi, Quinn, and Regan 2015; Toft 2009; Wolff 2011.

95. Cammett et al. 2022.

96. Karim 2020a. While we are unable to compare elite preferences to non-elite preferences for state building, budget spending sheds some light on this, and it shows that political elites prioritize different sectors.

97. Barnhart and Trager 2023; Eichenberg 2019.

to prefer the rebuilding of special forces because these types of groups are often involved in sexual and gender-based violence.⁹⁸

Women may also prefer the (re)construction of administrative institutions over security institutions for other reasons. Increasing administrative capacity (for example, via post offices that issue identification cards) makes women more legible to the state,⁹⁹ and land institutions help civilians acquire land titles, which are crucial for women's economic empowerment.¹⁰⁰ Thus, some of the variation by sex could be driven by a preference for improvements in the administrative capacity of states as an avenue for their empowerment.

Second, we find that higher-income individuals prefer security-oriented institutions. This is consistent with findings that higher-income individuals prefer stronger policing and security measures.¹⁰¹ In contrast, lower-income civilians may be more likely to benefit from an expanded administrative state and see less benefit from expanded security forces, perhaps because they are disproportionately likely to be targeted by such institutions.¹⁰²

Finally, we find meaningful variation in respondents' state-building preferences based on their wartime-victimization status. Those who experienced a mild degree of community-level wartime violence are less likely to prefer the security-oriented institution, as compared to those who did not experience any form of violence (Figure 2). Although this may seem puzzling, recent work has found that those who experience a minimal level of wartime violence may be particularly supportive of welfare-oriented institutions, as such experiences may increase prosocial behavior.¹⁰³ Nevertheless, the relationship may be parabolic because those who are on the extreme ends of the wartime-victimization scale—that is, “none” and “severe”—favor security-oriented institutions at similar rates.

Ultimately, our findings along this second dimension of state building suggest that civilians in Liberia have a strong preference for the (re)construction of security-oriented institutions. However, not all civilians share this preference, with important differences across sex, socioeconomic status, and wartime victimization.

Results for Form of Involvement

Turning to the third dimension of international state building, we find that civilians prefer that state builders engage in more limited, indirect forms of state building rather than direct forms. The estimand for the former (here, “monitored the reconstruction of”) is 0.512 (Figure 1). This is not only positive and statistically

98. Cohen and Nordås 2015; Willis 2021.

99. Harbers 2020; Hunter 2019.

100. Agarwal 1994; Allendorf 2007.

101. Rosen and Cutrona 2021.

102. For example, according to participants, the security forces banned motorbikes in Liberia in 2013, whose drivers are primarily of a lower socioeconomic status. The perceived encroachment on their livelihood by the police led to protest and violence.

103. Berens and Karim 2024.

significant but also distinct from the estimand for the latter (here, “has rebuilt”): 0.487.

As with the other two dimensions, these results align with previous work on the effectiveness of international state-building efforts. Research has shown that state-building efforts that bypass domestic actors to impose reforms often fail because they lack input legitimacy.¹⁰⁴ This also appears to be the case in situations of delegated authority: international state builders that engage in negotiated forms of influence—instead of “complete takeovers”¹⁰⁵—allow domestic oversight, inclusion, and thus ownership over the process.¹⁰⁶ In this way, the results suggest that civilians prefer forms of state building that implicitly necessitate a degree of domestic involvement in the process.

At the same time, these significant results we observe in the aggregate may be primarily driven by wartime victimization. The primary difference we observe is for individuals without any community-level wartime victimization (Figure 2). While these individuals may hold particularly strong attitudes toward each form of involvement, victims of wartime violence may place less emphasis on how state building takes place. This may be determined by priorities similar to those of low-income individuals—that is, a focus on *what* reforms are made, rather than *how*. Alternatively, it may be driven by a desire to ensure that such processes are successfully executed. Recent work suggests that more direct forms of participation are better at ensuring that reforms are implemented,¹⁰⁷ and victims of wartime violence may also prefer that decisive action be taken in periods of postconflict transition.¹⁰⁸ Thus, they may be relatively less willing to prioritize a limited form of actor involvement in the state-building process.

In sum, we find that civilians have strong preferences for more indirect, limited forms of international state building. However, as with the other dimensions, there can be meaningful heterogeneity across demographic subgroups, with victims of community-level wartime violence less likely to hold polarizing positions on the form of actor involvement.

Conclusion

Postconflict countries often receive state-building assistance from international actors, who engage in various institutional-reform initiatives through different modes of engagement. It is crucial to understand civilian preferences in this fragmented international state-building environment because these preferences not only impact state-building outcomes but also are central to local ownership processes.¹⁰⁹

104. Blair, di Salvatore, and Smidt 2023; Lake and Fariss 2014.

105. Campbell and Matanock 2024.

106. Ibid.; Matanock 2014.

107. Mailhot 2025a.

108. Samii 2013.

109. Ejodus 2017; von Billerbeck 2017.

We explicate three primary dimensions along which international state building may vary—the actor, the targeted institution, and the form of involvement—and we leverage a series of original surveys fielded across Liberia to assess how variation along each dimension impacts civilians’ state-building preferences. The findings provide a handful of meaningful insights.

First, Liberians’ preferences do indeed vary along each of these three core dimensions, but they also hold significantly consistent preferences for each dimension. Specifically, respondents strongly prefer indirect state-building processes, targeted at security-oriented institutions and overseen by the US, the UN, and (to a lesser extent) the Liberian government, rather than China. Regarding the latter, though our work is exploratory, we find suggestive evidence of consistently negative attitudes toward Chinese-backed state-building processes. Our supplementary analyses suggest that this latter finding may be driven by both individuals’ subjective perceptions of the country and their objective experiences of wartime violence.

Second, Liberian civilians strongly prefer security-oriented state-building processes over non-security-oriented processes. However, this polarization is weaker among women, lower-income individuals, and those with less exposure to wartime victimization.

Third, civilians generally prefer indirect, less involved forms of international state building over more direct, hands-on forms, though individuals without any community-level exposure to wartime victimization may be driving these results.

Taken together, these results offer researchers, policymakers, and practitioners meaningful insights into civilians’ preferences for international state building. They suggest that wartime victimization influences individuals’ preferences regarding postconflict state-building processes. This has important implications for long-term state-building efforts, as it suggests that wartime experiences continue to shape individuals’ political preferences for decades afterward. Such legacies should therefore be prioritized when considering how to engage in state building.

Our findings also support a soft, cautious optimism for internationally backed state-building efforts. While an emerging body of research has, importantly, drawn attention to the challenges that state building faces,¹¹⁰ we find that, by and large, civilians in Liberia do desire international state-building assistance but also that such support is substantially conditioned on *which* features unfold in the process. This both reinforces and qualifies such scholarship. With this in mind, the question becomes not *whether* internationally backed state building is productive but rather *how* it may be. Consequently, these results from Liberia, as well as our explication of each dimension of the state-building process, serve to move these conversations forward.

Nevertheless, this study is not without limitations. Our results may be influenced by how we operationalize each dimension of state building and by country-specific features. While the UN, US, and China are leading state builders, other international actors, including Australia, the EU, Sweden, and the UK, are increasingly involved in

110. Autesserre 2014; Chandler 2010; Chesterman 2004; Ejodus 2017; Paris 2004; Richmond 2014.

the postconflict state-building process;¹¹¹ state building may also target a wider variety of institutions, including the judiciary and election institutions. Though our focus provides important theoretical and empirical insights, future research should explore how additional variation along each dimension may shape civilian preferences. This may be done, for example, through quantitative replications of our experiment using different institutions and actors elsewhere or through qualitative case studies.

Moreover, our analyses treat civilians' preferences as static. While this is useful for an initial conceptual and empirical exploration, state building is a dynamic process, and civilians' preferences may change over time, especially as international actors become embedded in such contexts.¹¹² Future studies should therefore examine how and when such preferences change to provide a more complete picture of the relationship between public opinion and internationally backed state-building processes.

Data Availability Statement

Replication files for this research note may be found at <<https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/IES0FO>>.

Supplementary Material

Supplementary material for this research note is available at <<https://doi.org/10.1017/S0020818325100829>>.

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111. Mailhot 2025b.

112. Mailhot 2025c.

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